

Discharge Information

Lower Spine Fusion

You were in the hospital for surgery on the spinal bones (vertebrae) in your lower back.

This handout tells you and your caregiver what you need to know about your care in the first weeks at home. Ask your doctor or nurse if there are things you do not understand.

Follow-up Appointments

Name of Doctor	Day & Time	Phone Number
1.		
2.		
3.		



Eating Plan

- Eat your usual foods unless your doctor gave you a special eating plan.
- Add more fiber to your eating plan to help prevent hard stools (constipation). Fiber is in whole grains, vegetables, and fruits.
- Stay at a healthy weight. Being overweight adds more strain to your back. Ask your doctor what a good weight for you would be.
- The foods you eat can affect the way the blood thinner warfarin (Coumadin) works. If you take warfarin:
 - Eat the same foods you always eat unless your doctor told you not to.
 - Keep the amount of foods you eat with vitamin K the same every day. Vitamin K is in broccoli, spinach, kale, and other dark green leafy vegetables. Eating more of these foods than usual can change how your blood thinner works.
- Alcohol can affect the way your blood thinner works. If you take this medicine, limit alcohol to 1 or 2 drinks a week. This includes beer, wine, hard liquor, and mixed drinks.



Activity

- Your doctor and physical therapist will tell you what types of exercises you should do and how often you should do them.
- Keep doing the exercises your therapist taught you in the hospital.
- Avoid activities that make you bend over or lift heavy objects until your doctor tells you it is OK. These include vacuuming, lifting groceries or full garbage bags, and doing laundry.
- Avoid contact sports such as football, martial arts, ice hockey, and wrestling. If you play other sports, ask your doctor when it is safe to begin these again.
- Do not drive or return to work until your doctor says it is OK.



Self-Care

- Keep all doctor appointments. Ask the doctor if all shots (vaccines) are up to date.
- Know who you want called in case of an emergency, like a family member. Keep their contact information in a place it can be found quickly, like a cell phone, wallet, or bag.
- Take care of your wound as you were taught. Only use skin cleansers or lotions on the wound if the doctor tells you to.
- Find ways to relax to cut down pain, such as taking deep breaths or listening to music.
- If you have a splint or immobilizer, wear it as you were told.
 - Take care of the skin underneath it as you were taught.
 - Keep the immobilizer clean and dry when not in use.
- Prevent blood clots in your legs.
 - Keep your legs propped up while lying down.
 - Avoid sitting for long periods of time. If you do, stretch your legs as much as you can. Do not cross your legs while sitting.

- Do not wear socks with tight bands that leave marks on your legs.
- Wear compression stockings every day if your doctor told you to.
- Take blood thinner medicine if your doctor orders it.
- If you wear elastic compression stockings on your legs:
 - Make sure the stockings go on smoothly with no wrinkles.
 - Do not let the stockings roll down. This can cut off blood flow to your feet.
 - Wear the stockings during the day. Take them off at night. Check your skin every time you take them off.
- If you or your caregiver needs to give you a shot:
 - Give the shots the way you were taught.
 - Rotate the shots to different parts of your body.
 - Keep all supplies together. Follow the proper steps to get rid of used supplies.
- If you are on a blood thinner, get a medical ID bracelet, necklace, or card for your wallet that says you take this medicine. Carry it at all times.
- Help prevent bleeding if you are at risk.
 - Use a soft toothbrush. Floss gently to avoid bleeding.
 - Use an electric razor to shave.
 - Blow your nose gently.
 - Keep your nails short and smooth to prevent scratches.
- Reduce your risk of falls. Keep the floor and walkways clear. Wear shoes with nonskid soles. Get up slowly from sitting or lying down.
- If you smoke, you should stop now. Talk to your doctor about ways to help you quit.



Medicines

- When you leave the hospital, you should get:
 - A list of all the medicines you should take
 - Prescriptions for any new medicines
- Take your medicine as your doctor asked you to.
 - Talk to your doctor before you stop taking a medicine.
 - Keep a list of all the medicines you take. Include your prescription medicines, and vitamins, herbs, and medicines you buy at the store.
 - Take the medicine list to every doctor or hospital visit.
 - Get the follow-up tests that your doctor orders.
- Prevent problems with your blood thinner medicine.
 - Take your medicine every day at the same time.
 - Tell all your doctors and dentists you take this medicine.
 - Avoid activities with a high risk of getting hurt.
 - Do not use aspirin or ibuprofen unless your doctor says it is OK. Ask your doctor before you take vitamins, herbs, or medicines you buy at the store.
 - Give your doctor a list of all your medicines. Have your doctor check that other medicines do not affect the blood thinner medicine.
 - Ask your doctor what to do if you miss a dose. Do not take 2 doses at the same time to make up for the missed dose.
- To cut down your pain, take the pain medicine before activities that can hurt, such as therapy, exercise, or dressing changes.
- These programs help you pay for prescription medicines if you cannot afford them.
 - NeedyMeds. Go to: www.needymeds.org

- Medicine Assistance Tool (MAT). Go to:
<https://medicineassistancetool.org>



When to Call for Emergency Help

- You have trouble breathing.
- You suddenly start having chest pain.
- Your bandage is soaked with blood.
- You cannot move your leg or toes.
- You are not able to stop your urine or bowel movements when you want to.
- You feel burning, numbness, tingling, or a cool feeling in your toes or feet.
- You have signs of a blood clot in your leg.
 - Your leg is red and swollen.
 - There is swelling, warmth, and tenderness along a vein in your leg.



When to Call Your Surgeon

- Pain medicine does not help the pain.
- You have a fever over 100.4 or chills.
- You cannot stand up straight.
- You have problems with the wound.
 - The wound changes in color.
 - There is a warm feeling around the wound.
 - The wound opens up.
 - There is bleeding, pus, or a bad smell coming from the wound.
- You have problems with the immobilizer.

- The skin around the edges of the immobilizer is red or sore.
- You feel a blister forming under the immobilizer.
- The immobilizer gets tight or very loose.
- You take blood thinner medicine and have problems.
 - You bruise easily.
 - Your gums, skin, or nose bleeds.
 - Your bleeding does not stop after 10 or 15 minutes.
 - There is blood in your urine.
 - Your stools are black or bloody.
 - You throw up (vomit) blood or the vomit looks like coffee grounds.
 - You cough up blood.
- You fall.



When to Call Your Regular Doctor

- Your stools are very hard, or you have not had any in 3 days (constipation).
- You have a cough that does not stop.
- You have other medical problems.



To Learn More

- American Academy of Orthopaedic Surgeons (AAOS). Go to: www.orthoinfo.org
- National Institutes of Health. Go to: www.smokefree.gov

This information is general in nature and may not apply to you or your condition. Talk to your doctor or nurse about how to best use this information and how to take care of your medical condition. Be sure to ask your doctor or nurse any questions you might have. This information sheet is not intended to provide or replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.

Patient or Caregiver:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Nurse:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Medicine List

Name: _____

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